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by alcarian

Summary

Catra has been alone for years now, ever since Adora left on a scholarship track in high school.
Now sophomore year of college is here, and she has a new roommate... how will they navigate their reunion, and what has changed?

Chapter 1

Chapter Notes

Hallo everyone, this be my first fic. I caught the She-Ra brainrot bug a while back now, and the spark inspiration of one scene caused all of this.
This is also my first writing work I've ever posted publicly which is kinda crazy.
We will swap between Catra and Adora POV throughout, sometimes within one chapter potentially. I will always mark POV with a header!

Catra

The dorm was four stories of red bricks, woven through with ivy, broken up regularly by large, recently modernised, glass windows. The wide double door was swung open and a steady stream of freshman, and their families, carrying boxes and bags wove through into the hall. Catra was not one of them. She sat cross-legged on her own meagre pile of things, tail twitching back and forth, as she watched through the windows as the new students put up their posters and flags in their rooms, all grins and laughter as their parents teared up with pride. Catra was content to wait, though, she would rather avoid the effort of forcing her way through the throng and press of happy idiots. She'd done as much last year; she wasn't going to make the same mistake this time, the crowd would need to be at least half as thick before she made a move. *The second year in these dorms* she thought to herself *no one to talk to, nothing to do*. The joys of having no home… she was thankful that Etheria University had let her stay in dorms over the summer, even if she had to work that checkout at the corner store for most of the holiday to afford it. She'd procrastinated moving her crap to the room they were moving her into for this year though, so she'd had to pile her boxes and bags outside to avoid being stuck in the corridors with the hoard. It wasn't all bad, the weather was nice, and her earbuds kept her plenty enough company as she watched the people go by.

The morning had gone by the time that crowd had thinned enough for Catra to be happy, but thin it finally did. She hopped off her boxes and stretched her legs out to get the feeling back in, she'd been sat for a while after all. She heaved the huge duffle bag that had all her clothes over one shoulder then hefted the few small boxes of books and bits and bobs into her arms. She swayed, unsteady, with the weight for a moment before making her slow way into the building. *This is gonna suck* she bemoaned silently, albeit with a small groan. Room 3C was up two flights of stairs from here. Why hadn't she moved her things

yesterday? She'd had the chance; the room was unoccupied. She was already aching by the time she reached the stairwell.

A voice interrupted her silent struggle "Hey Catra, need any help?" it called. Dr Micah, the Dean of Sorcery, stood a few stairs up. He'd been helping freshmen find their room and carry their things, she guessed. He was a nice guy, she'd liked his classes last year, even if sorcery eluded her, practically and theoretically. He was never awful about her lack of aptitude, unlike… some.

"Yeah, thanks Dr Mike" she smirked, dumping the boxes she carried into his outstretched arms. He just smiled at the lack of respect; an eyebrow half raised. Yeah, he was alright in her books. "3C's where we're going" He turned with a simple acknowledgement and Catra, now with her hands free, took her earbuds out in case he wanted to talk to her. It was a good call, unsurprisingly, Micah always liked to talk.

"So, taking any Sorcery classes again this year?"

"I don't know, Doc. Maybe?" she'd not chosen any electives this year, yet. "Promise not to fail me?"

"Depends, will you do the work?" she couldn't see his face, but she could hear his smile.

"Mmm, I don't know about that, will it make any sense?"

"You know you understand it, you just need to put the effort in."

She answered that with stoney silence. Thankfully they'd just got to the room. Dr Micah turned to open the door with an elbow and pushed his way into the room, and Catra followed. A voice called out that stopped her dead in her tracks, framed in the doorway.

"Hey, new roomie I'm guessing?" the voice came from under the bed to the left. The bed was covered with a simple blue duvet, with white pillows. The source of the voice was the bottom half of a kneeling girl stuck out from underneath the bed. *It can't be that voice* Catra thought as she froze, her tail lashing up, *she's a thousand miles away*. "I'll be out in a sec, just plugging things in."

Catra jerked her head down to look at the door. Dr Micah had covered it as he opened it but there, on the door, was that little whiteboard that people could write their names on in stupid little personal ways. Her new roommate had already done it, and there was the proof. Written in a big but neat hand, underlined with a little swoosh, and punctuated with a little smiley was her name. *Adora,* it read, and Catra's heart shot into her throat. She looked back into the room to see that Dr Micah had already put her boxes down on the empty desk to the right and was making for the door, his eyebrow cocked at Catra's frozen state. Behind him was where her eyes were locked, however. There Adora was, rising, her golden hair glowing in the sun pouring through plate window as she adjusted her ponytail. A soft smile played on her face as she stood fully and looked to the door.

"Ok! Let's do this, I'm- "Adora's eyes locked with Catra's own, and her smile dropped into shock, and then into a beaming grin. "Oh my god, Catra!?" she froze even harder as Adora rushed to her and wrapped her into a hug. She found her own arms wrapping around Adora as she hoisted Catra, heavy duffle bag and all, into a spin.

"But you don't go here?" Catra said disbelieving, when she'd been put down, though not let go. "I thought?"

"I do now!" Adora pulled out of the hug, leaving her hands on Catra's shoulders. "I can't believe I got roomed with you! I was going to ask around and see if you were about, but here you are!"

This is a dream; I passed out on the stairs. Catra couldn't believe Adora was here. *She left me behind.* But here Adora was, a little taller than last she'd seen her, but clearly just as strong, she was wearing a simple pair of sweats and a baggy shirt, but it was obvious still. *You're staring at her, say something!*

"I thought you were off at your fancy pants college with your fancy pants scholarship?" *Don't be mean!* She chastised herself.

"Oh… yeah.. that didn't pan out. So, I'm here! Is that… ok?" Adora's blue eyes studied Catra's face, looking for something. *Is that ok, she asks! Is it ok!? She's HERE!*

"Ok!? It's awesome!" Catra pulled her back into the hug and held her tightly. "You're back! You're here! We're back!" she felt almost like she would explode as they held each other. Her best friend was back, back here, with her. She was almost crying as they finally pulled apart.

"Let me take this." Adora pulled Catra's bag off her shoulder with an arm and turned to put it on the bare bed on the right. Catra hadn't noticed when Dr Micah had left, but he'd gone at some point, hopefully early. She watched as Adora dropped the bag on her bed and went to sit on her own. She really could barely believe it. They were roommates! It would be almost like their sleepovers of old. They'd had them as often as they could, from when they'd met at the start of middle school. Adora's fosters at the time were lovely and more than happy to let the girls all but live together half the time. Catra's own foster parents couldn't have cared less. It was all flooding back as she watched Adora scoot back a bit on her bed, getting comfortable. The joy of years of being joined at the hip, looking out for each other. She was also remembering high school… when most of Adora's time was taken by her stupid team… and that day, junior year of high school. Adora had come to Catra's house, tears in her eyes, and told her of the scholarship track her foster parents had found for her. *Years ago,* Catra shook her head, trying to clear it. *It doesn't matter, she's back, she's here and you're STARING AGAIN.*

Catra moved quickly to start unpacking her things, unzipping the big duffle on her bed and dumping everything out. "So, what was fancy-pants academy like?" she asked, both curious and desperate to fill the silence.

"Oh, it was ok I guess."

"Just ok?" Catra turned around to look at Adora. Her heart leapt into her throat again as their eyes met. Something in Adora's looked sad. "Not what you were looking for?"

"No, it was fine! I just… I guess I couldn't keep up." Adora gave her a reassuring smile. "They revoked the scholarship when my grades fell."

"Oh, that sucks. Sorry"

"Yeah a little, it's ok, but we're here now though!" *You're damn right* Catra thought. She looked away and started to unpack her clothes into the big dresser next to the bed, hiding her smile. She felt bad about being so happy, Adora really wanted that scholarship, that college. "What's this place like though?" Adora asked.

"Oh, ok too, I guess." Catra chuckled at the repeated sentiment. "Most of the classes are fine. Dr Mike, who had my boxes, is cool, but watch out for Shadow Weaver, she's a bitch frankly." Adora's laugh sang about the room and Catra's heart leapt again. *What is WITH me!?* She looked back at Adora to see that she had started putting Catra's bedding on. "Hey, you don't have to."

"It's quicker with two people" Adora beamed at her. "What about friends, or…?" she pumped her eyebrows at Catra, and it was her turn to laugh.

"No, no, no not really. Everyone's fine, I guess. It's just… I'm alright with just me." Catra hoped she wouldn't see through the lie. *I've been alone, Adora. Ever since you went.* "What about you?"

"There were some cool people, the team was great, but I didn't really have time for much or anything outside of practice and trying to keep my grades up." Adora was busy not looking at Catra now, carefully tucking in the corners of the bedsheet. Catra watched her smooth over the creases with a gentle hand. She could be making it up but there seemed a sadness in Adora's there. *Does she just miss her cool college or is it…*

"I'm sorry it didn't pan out." Catra said, to distract from her wandering mind, but she meant it too. She sat on her bed, facing Adora stood over it, and put her hand on Adora's. "I know you really wanted it."

"It's ok… really!" their eyes were locked again and Adora's were crinkled with the smile she was giving Catra. She seemed to really mean it. Catra returned her smile and squeezed her hand. They sat for a moment, like that, hand in hand and looking into each other's eyes before Catra twisted away and hopped to sit on the top of her dresser.

"So, you got any plans after you're all unpacked?" Catra broke the silence, feet kicking lightly against the drawers below. Adora looked about to her side of the room. Her bed was neatly made, the end of the duvet folded perfectly by the pillows, her dresser and desk bare save for a small silver laptop laying closed on her desktop. Then she looked to Catra's duvet, which she was pulling the cover over, and to her desk littered with the boxes Dr Micah had left there. She smirked at Catra as she finished buttoning up the end of the cover. "Ugh fine" Catra sighed, hopping off the dresser and moving to unpack the boxes. "But seriously, doing anything?"

"I need to get some posters and things to hang, I hate the bare walls. *Fancy pants* didn't let us decorate our Dorms." Adora nudged Catra to the side, taking one of the boxes to unpack herself. "But that's probably for another day. Dr Micah mentioned his daughter Glimmer was holding a thing for

sophomores at their house, a welcome back thing? I thought about going to that. Do you know her?"

"Uh yeah, I guess, not really" Glimmer was the daughter of Dr Micah and Angella, who was the headmistress. A perfect student but she also held a lot of parties and mixers and things. Catra had never gone, she didn't remember if she'd been invited at all, honestly. "She's nice? I haven't really talked to her."

"I think it would be a good opportunity to meet people." Adora was almost finished with the box she'd picked, neatly lining up the books and things at the back of the desk. "I think it would be good if you came too!" Catra had barely touched the things in her chosen box. The prospect of a party with a bunch of people seemed less horrible if Adora would be there, but still unpleasant.

"Yeah I'll come, sure."

"Thank you." she smiled warmly and nudged Catra. Adora grabbed the third, largest, box and opened it and gasped. Catra looked over and her tail whipped up. Lying at the top of the pile of otherwise junk inside was a small picture frame. Only a few inches square it held a small polaroid picture of Catra and Adora, no more than twelve or thirteen, sat leaning against each other at a table, grinning huge idiotic grins at the camera. Adora's foster mom had written simply "the girls" under the picture in thick black marker.

"Oh my god." Adora said softly, lifting it lightly from the box. "I didn't know you had this." Catra looked into her own packing box, blinking heavily to fight the tears. She adored that picture, yet she couldn't look at it. It was her greatest treasure, yet it always lived in whatever her most bottom drawer was. *But she's back.* She forced herself to look at Adora, still blinking back her stupid tears. *She's really here.* Adora pulled her into a tight hug, where Catra tucked her head against Adora's neck.

"I really missed you." Catra's voice cracked.

"I really missed you too."

I love you. Catra thought. *Wait WHAT?*

Chapter 2

Chapter Notes

Just a shorter one. First Adora POV!
Have fun.

Adora

Neither of them had changed clothes for Glimmer's party. It wasn't a big bash or anything, Dr Micah had said, just a get together for the sophomores who were on campus so far. The evening was warm, too, so whatever sweats and a whatever shirt were fine. Adora had just pressed the doorbell and was stepping back to stand next to Catra. She was dressed pretty much the same, though she'd torn the sleeves off her black t-shirt at some point, judging by the frayed edges. Her hair was a wild tumble down to her shoulders, as always. *She really does look the same* Adora thought *Like everything was the same, like I didn't abandon her.* Her ears were twitching though, along with her tail, and she was looking to the side away from the door. Adora reached out to her gently, rubbing a shoulder.

"Hey, you ok?"

"Yeah whatever." Catra huffed "I'm just not great at these… things."

"Parties?"

"No, people."

Adora laughed a little at that, and Catra looked sideways at her with a little smirk. "You'll be ok, I'm right here." Adora reassured her, reaching down to take her hand. They waited for a few moments more outside the huge, almost, manor house. Adora let out a held breath as Catra let her hold her hand. Catra had seemed tense since before they'd left their room. *She never did like parties much, but this is more than that*, Adora mused, *does she actually really not like people here?*. Adora's thoughts were interrupted by the creak of the door handle turning and Catra suddenly yanking her hand from Adora's. She looked quickly to Catra to see her stuffing her hands in her pockets, tail twitching back and forth, before looking back to the door. Revealed there was a girl, shorter than Catra, wearing a simple

light purple dress. A short shock of pink hair framed her grinning face as she stepped out a little bit.

"Hi! I'm Glimmer, you must be Adora! Great to meet you!" she beamed at Adora. "My dad said there might be a new girl coming, and Catra!" she turned to look at her "You actually came!"

"I didn't know I was invi-AH!" Catra was cut off by a flash of light, Glimmer was suddenly between them, yanking their arms and pulling them both into the house. If the outside had been impressive, the inside was more. Hardwood flooring, a huge staircase with a dark shiny wood banister, that went up to a landing and down to a basement. To the one side the hallway opened up into a massive kitchen with a central island and what looked like some really fancy kit. To the other, a set of open double doors showed a huge living room bedecked with a massive flatscreen and recliner sofas. A corridor by the staircase ran past, from the front of the house to the back. Voices and laughter rang out from the descending staircase as, in another flash of light, Glimmer was back past them closing the front door.

"Welcome to my home! Everyone's downstairs, and Mom and Dad are staying with my aunt tonight, so we don't have to worry about noise or anything!" Glimmer flashed, again, to the top of the stairs, back facing towards the stairs to the basement, gesturing for Adora and Catra to follow. Adora started to move first, as Glimmer turned on one heel on a stair and all but ran down the stairs, Catra lagged behind a little but came when Adora looked back at her, with a smile. The stairs clunked and thudded solidly under Adora's shoes, and the voices got louder along with the sounds of some game. The bottom of the staircase opened into a room that must have been as large as almost the entire ground floor, with a few doors off of it. A flatscreen even larger than the one upstairs was hung against one wall and opposite it were another set of reclining sofas. The other end of the room from the staircase was occupied by what looked like a bar, complete with stools and taps.

At the bar, a guy with honestly a great moustache was pouring a glass of something for himself and a girl, whose hair and jacket and pants were a deep sea blue, leaning against it. *Someone's got a theme?* Adora thought as she looked at the sofas. The three two seaters were occupied, not fully, by a tall girl with a white undercut pixie haircut sat next to another girl with long blonde hair, a long light flowy pink dress and a flower in her hair. On the other sofa, sat by himself, but looking up at the stairs as they came in, was a boy wearing a crop top with a tattoo of something peeking out under a sleeve. All three on the sofas were furiously mashing the buttons on their controllers as little characters smacked each other about on the flatscreen.

"Ok, so!" Glimmer said as Adora reached the bottom of the stairs, turning back to look at her and Catra "That's Sea Hawk and Mermista" she pointed to moustache and sea blue by the bar, the former gave a big wave while the latter just looked at them. "That's Bow" she pointed to crop top "and that's Scorpia and Perfuma!", undercut and flowers. "There'd usually be more people, but I guess most sophomores are arriving tomorrow!" she smiled apologetically at Adora, "Aaand everyone! This is new girl Adora! And you've met Catra" The group all cheered greetings in unison at the pair, a cacophony of "Heys" and "Hellos". Glimmer finished off asking "Do you guys know each other or just arrived together?" Adora thought she saw Glimmer look to a space between her and Catra's hands.

"We're roommates" Catra answered simply, quickly.

"Yeah, and we were friends ages before college too" Adora looked sideways at Catra. *Am I not supposed to tell people? Why not?* Catra wouldn't catch her eye though.

"That's great! Already knowing someone here." Bow piped up. His voice was warm, and he had an infectious cheery manner. Glimmer flashed again to sit right by him and immediately rested her head on his shoulder as he un-paused the game to indignant cries from Scorpia and Perfuma. Adora dropped herself onto the empty sofa and Catra hopped lightly to sit cross legged in the seat

next to her, furthest away from anyone else. Perfuma, who was closest to Adora and seemingly out of the game now, turned to Adora.

“So, what got you to come to Etheria?” she asked her.

“Oh uh.” It all came back through her mind again. Sitting alone in the locker room. Long evenings staring at her ceiling or walls, whichever was more interesting that day. Meals alone, walks alone, sitting silently in classes. “I had a scholarship elsewhere, but it fell through, so I thought why not come home? I grew up around here.”

“Scholarship for what?” asked Bow after Scorpia cheered her victory and jumped up to go to the bar. Catra stood and followed her, and Adora watched her go.

“Oh, Rugby. Weird one I know.”

“Not weird at all!” cheered Sea Hawk as he plopped down in Scorpia’s empty seat. “Why, Bow here is on the team himself!”

“Yeah, well, I was last year, but it’s not a guarantee. Try-outs are the day after tomorrow, you gonna go?” Bow asked Adora.

“I think so, yeah. Not sure I’d know what to do with myself otherwise.”

“Well, I’ll be sure to give you hell” he grinned, before starting up a new round after Mermista sat next to Adora. Scorpia dragged two of the stools from the bar to behind the middle sofa, and Catra handed Adora an ice cold beer. Adora looked up to her and smiled and Catra smiled back down before hopping onto the stool next to Scorpia. Eventually someone tossed Adora a controller and her focus was taken by the game. She knew it decently well, game characters and things trying to smack each other off of a stage with abilities and items. She was no match for the others though. In a lull, after she ran out of lives, it was hard to tell what with the noise of the game and how quickly she’d been drinking her beer, but she thought she might have heard, in muffled tones,

Scorpia say "*the* Adora" to Catra and Catra replying "shut UP". She was trying to shove the much bigger girl off of her stool, to no avail, when Adora glanced over, it made her smile.

The next few hours were full of video games – they switched to some go-karting one, that Adora was terrible at, but Catra stole her controller, sticking her tongue out at Adora – cold drinks, and great chatting. Everyone seemed really nice, even Mermista who clearly wanted to be aloof. It didn't take long for Adora to notice that it wasn't just Bow and Glimmer who were "a thing", Sea Hawk and Mermista, and Scorpia and Perfuma were clearly "things" too. She felt, suddenly, a flush of awkwardness when she realised that and glanced at Catra, who was too busy drifting her go-kart across a finish line to see. It was good to see her having fun though, her tongue sticking out and tail flicking about in concentration with every corner she took. As the alcohol flowed more, she found herself looking more and more at Catra. They'd not spoken much since getting here, but Catra seemed to be comfortable next to Scorpia, and focused on her controller. Everyone shuffled seats a few times, as people got up to refill or get new drinks or go to the bathroom. Eventually, Adora and Catra were stood at the bar together as Adora tossed their latest crumpled cans into the small bin under the bar.

"Hey…" Catra said, stretching her arms above her head, interrupted by a yawn. "I'm getting pretty tired."

"Yeah? You wanna head out?"

"Can we?"

"Hey guys!" Adora answered by talking to the room. "We're gonna go, we've still got to walk back to campus."

Everyone made noises of dissent and Glimmer said that they would have been ok to stay if they had the room, looking apologetically at the others. They all exchanged phone numbers, even Catra which Adora was happy to see, and Glimmer promised to make a group chat with them all in before she walked them up

to the door and hugged them goodbye, much to Catra's distress. The sun was nearly set as they set off back towards campus. They walked in silence for the first few streets, but at one moment their hands bumped each other and Adora found her hand seized by Catra as they walked.

"Everyone was really great!" Adora finally broke the silence.

"Yeah, you seemed to really get on with everyone."

"I thought you did too? What about Scorpia? You seemed to get along"

"Everyone loved talking to you… Scorpia is cool I guess though. We were like friends a little last year until she met Perfuma."

"Still look like friends to me." ***The*** *Adora she had said,* Adora remembered, and her heart fluttered. She looked over to Catra to find Catra looking at her, she gave her a smile. "I just hope you had a good time? You were good at that go-kart game."

"Yeah." Catra returned her smile, albeit it weaker. "Yeah, ok, I guess I did."

"That's good! I did too." Catra just squeezed her hand.

The silence descended again, but Adora was quite happy enough to just walk with Catra. After the few drinks that they had, they stumbled into each other a couple times and Adora loved listening to Catra's giggle whenever they did. By the time they got back to their dorm the sun was nearly full set, and everything was bathed in a golden glow, the air was cool but not cold, and a few birds sang in the trees around the lawn. As they crossed the grass Catra stopped suddenly.

"Can we stay out here for a sec?" she looked up at Adora. "It's perfect out and…" she trailed off, just smiling.

"Yeah of course we can." Adora sat down in the grass, cross legged leaning back on her hands, and Catra all but curled up

next to her, her head leaning on Adora's shoulder.

"Thank you…" Catra murmured, after a brief pause. "I'm really glad you're back."

Adora didn't respond apart from to rest her head atop Catra's. They sat there, the setting sun washing over them. Catra began to purr softly after a moment and, while it was only quiet, it became the only sound in Adora's world. *I'm really glad I'm back, too*. She closed her eyes and basked. When she opened her eyes again, the sun had gone, the moon was coming up, the birds had stopped singing, and Catra's purring had turned into light snoring. Adora smiled and turned slowly to scoop Catra into her arms. She stood and carried her gently into the dorm, up the flights of stairs and into their room. She tucked Catra into her bed before getting into her pjs and climbing into her own bed.

She lay, sideways, looking across the room, gazing at Catra's face illuminated in the faint moonlight filtering through their blinds until her eyes wouldn't stay open anymore.

Chapter 3

Catra

"She-Ra?" Catra sniggered "Seriously? Still?"

"Yeah!" Adora responded, chest puffing indignantly, a blush rising to her ears. "I still think she's cool!" The first week of classes had gone by and they had found their timetables didn't match up much, if at all, so Adora had suggested they head into town and do some shopping for posters, and otherwise just hang out. Catra had been quick to agree. They were in a store, now, one of those ones where you get all your nerdy nick-nacks from comic book character dolls to band posters. Adora was flicking through the display and had settled on one of that big warrior lady, myth turned comic book hero, She-Ra she'd always loved. It was those comics that had got Adora in the gym for the first time, Catra remembered. "What about you?" Adora rebutted, pointing at the posters in Catra's arms, and the shirt she was wearing. "You still like The Horde, that's not changed!"

Catra cackled at Adora going bright red and shrugged at Adora's rallying shot. "Yeah The Horde is still good music, even if they did break up." Adora started to withdraw her arm from the little slot marked "23" where the She-Ra poster, all rolled up, was nestled. "Hey no, I didn't mean it like that" Catra reached and grabbed the poster and pulled it into Adora's hand. "You think she's cool, get the poster. I was just surprised!" *God why am I always mean to her*. "Hell, I think she's cool! Who wouldn't love a buff lady with a sword to come rescue them?" Catra was relieved to hear Adora chuckle and feel her take the poster.

"I always wanted to be the buff lady" Adora smirked at Catra, and her heart thudded into her throat yet again. That happened too much these days. Adora was back, and it was great, but something had changed. She had found herself, even in just the week that Adora had been back, heart pounding and face flushing at small things Adora said. She had found herself staring at Adora as she worked at her desk in their room, and she lounged in her bed. At Glimmer's party she had focused on that

game to stop herself staring in front of everyone, and Scorpia had called her "*The* Adora" *Too loudly* Catra grumbled to herself, but she was beginning to think Scorpia was right. *When did this happen, Adora?* Catra mused *when did you become The girl?* Adora had started away from the posters now, towards the checkout, and Catra watched as her ponytail swished with each step.

They paid for their posters and left the store into the warm early autumn day. "Where to next?" Adora asked, looking around for anything that sparked interest. There was another reason for their trip, Catra knew. Adora's try-outs had been earlier in the week and the team lists were going to be posted today, she was trying to distract herself from her nerves. Her new friend Bow was waiting by the notice board where they'd be pinned, and was going to let her know, but until then Adora needed distracting. Catra was more than happy to distract her, quite happy to spend this time with her. They'd had the mornings, afternoons and evenings, and this weekend to hang out, but Catra knew that when Adora got into varsity, as she definitely would, their time would get less and less. *Like last time, like in high school.* It wouldn't be like high school, Catra had promised herself though. They would still find the time. They had to.

"What about something to eat? Nearly time" Catra proposed, after a few more shops, and Adora checked her phone and nodded. The place they decided on was like a diner. All red booths and shiny tables. They ordered their cliche fries and milkshakes, Adora got a burger too. They sat in silence for a moment, Adora looking out the window, leaning on her hand and tapping the table with her other, while Catra looked at Adora. *She's nervous, she needs distracting, say something!* "So, how are you finding Etheria? Better than fancypants?" *That's NOTHING! Small talk? She's not a stranger what are you doing?*

"Yeah, so far. Dr Micah is cool, as you said, and…" Adora looked away from the window and back at Catra. The waitress coming and dropping their food off interrupted the rest of what she had to say. Adora tucked in with haste, always hungry.

Some things don't change Catra smiled to herself, picking at her fries. Adora continued, after half a burger "We'll see how things change with balancing class and practice and things… if I make the team." *AH! No stupid question Catra, of course it would bring it up.*

"You'll make it, there's no way you won't" Catra tried to reassure her. "You've always been star player. They've always loved you." Adora reached across the table and took Catra's hand and tried to give her a reassuring smile, but her other hand was still tapping out a tattoo on the seat next to her. Catra let silence descend again and returned to picking at her fries. She was still picking at them by the time Adora had finished her own food, so she slid the checker paper lined basket across the table to her. Adora's smile in response was exactly what Catra wanted to see. An ancient pattern between them, Adora almost always finished Catra's food. Adora had long since stopped asking if Catra was sure, if she didn't want to eat it herself.

They had finished, paid, left and were walking aimlessly about when Adora's phone beeped loudly in her pocket, Catra felt a buzz in hers too, a message to the group chat. Catra had walked a couple steps more before she realised Adora had stopped. Adora had her hand in her jacket pocket, but hadn't pulled her phone out, she just stood frozen looking at Catra. "I can't read it." Adora murmured, her eyes asking the silent question to Catra. Catra reached into her own pocket and pulled out her phone, raising an eyebrow at Adora, Adora nodded back at her. There on her lock screen, under the clock, was a notification. Bow had sent a photo to The Best Friend Squad (Bow had named the group, also). Catra tapped the notification and unlocked her phone. A picture of a little paper sheet filled the screen, an orderly list of names and numbers expected to be at practice. Next to a little number 8 was Scorpia, by number 9 was Bow's name, and a little bit further down next to a little number 12 was Adora's.

"Number 12, you're centre!" Catra cheered. She'd learned the positions and roles ages ago, Adora had made sure of

it. Adora, now, let out a huge sigh that she had been holding. She finally took out her own phone and looked. Adora scanned the list for a moment, nodding at names. When she saw her own name Adora stepped the few steps over to Catra and squeezed her into a bear hug, lifting her off her feet and blowing the air out of her lungs.

"Sorry, sorry" she said when she let Catra go "I always get worked up about this."

"I remember!" Catra stretched her arms out, shaking herself back into shape. *I remember…* Catra thought *"Sorry I've got practice, I can't", I remember.*

"Thank you for checking for me." Adora took her hand as they kept walking on. "I uh, I wanted to say as well." She paused, almost nervously "I know I… let it get away from me before… the game and the team. All of it" She stopped and pulled on Catra's hand to make her look at her. "I'm going to try, this time, really try. You're my best friend, you always will be, and I am not going to leave you behind again." Catra was stunned for moments, just looking into Adora's earnest blue eyes, glowing in the sunlight pouring down on the both of them. Adora's smile at her was determined, and the hand holding Catra's squeezed tightly.

"Should be easy, we actually do live together this time." Catra quipped and immediately berated herself *THIS ISN'T A JOKE CATRA BE REAL WITH HER*. "I… um… thank you." *Am I crying?* "You've always been my best friend too, always. You're always gonna be, too." Catra squeezed Adora's hand back. "and this time, I'm not letting you go anywhere." Catra's heart was thudding in her throat again, and just about everything else felt like it might just flutter away. *Is Adora crying!?* She yanked on Adora's hand and wrapped her arms around her. They stayed like that for what could have been forever. The sun beat down and the wind lightly lifted and blew Catra's hair about, but the only warmth she knew and the only touch she felt was Adora. She felt Adora's tension bleed out, her shoulders relax into the embrace,

Catra buried her head in Adora's neck, and she heard herself begin to purr. There was no one and nothing else in the world for this little forever.

"Now come on, let's go get the bus back." Catra sniffed when their eternity gave way and they walked again, hand in hand. "You've got a practice to get ready for." Adora started swinging their joined hands as they continued on, and Catra smiled to herself. She thought about what she felt after Adora had found their childhood picture – that lived, pride of place, on Catra's desk now – about what she had thought. She looked over at Adora and squeezed her hand, and Adora's grin back at her sent a bolt of lightning through Catra.

She did love her; she knew that now. Nothing was more clear to her in the world. She had loved her before her return, even before her leaving. From the moment they had met, locker to locker, on the first day of middle school. Maybe nothing had changed, really, maybe it just had taken her being back to make her know. Nothing else could explain how she had felt when she went. It had been such a sunny day, early in the summer, but it might just as well have been torrential downpour. The memory of Adora's tear streaked face contrasted with the warmth of her smile now. This time, Catra held her hand instead of the cold metal of a door handle slamming shut when she was gone. Adora was back, and she'd always been *THE* Adora, she always would be *THE* girl. *But she's not here because of you,* Catra's thoughts cursed her. The truth was vicious, it had taken a scholarship collapsing for Adora to come back. She couldn't pretend as if the leaving had been one moment, either. Adora's time had been the team and the game for too long before that. *But she is here,* she conceded, *we will make this effort, it won't happen again*. *I will not jeopardise it.* She could bury this old new feeling, she could be Adora's best friend again and forever. If that was what it took to be by her forever.

Bus doors hissed open in front of Catra, sending her hackles and tail shooting up. She almost hissed back before Adora laughing brought her back to reality. The bus had snuck up on her entirely. They climbed on board, one hand each full of bags packed with

posters and things for their room. Their bagless hands held each other still and Catra couldn’t stop smiling.

Chapter 4

Chapter Notes

You'll have to forgive me for the beginning of this chapter, my resurgent rugby obsession took hold as I typed.

Adora

The whistle blew and the two packs slammed into each other with a grunt and a cheer raising from the stands. Adora studied the line the other team had made, angled, ready for attack. The other team's scrum half tapped their prop with the ball and tossed it into the melee. With Scorpia as their anchor at number 8, the other team had no chance of moving their forwards. The other hooker was the faster, though, and the ball went flying out to their scrum half who dipped around the side, coming Adora's way. Etheria's openside flanker, Rogelio's scales flashed as he darted out of the scrum, diving to tackle the scrum half who was too quick for him and juked to the side. She was not quick enough for Adora, though, who slammed her shoulder into the half's thigh and wrapped her arms around her scrambling legs. Adora was quick back onto her feet, as she heard the ball caught by one of the scrum half's supporters, she dashed after them, eyes locked on the flapping number 10 on their shirt. Adora threw herself forwards to try and grab onto the fly half charging away, but only managed to whack one of their ankles. It was enough, though, sending them careening over their own feet. Adora's heart leapt a little as the attacking fly half lost grip of the ball, sending it forwards. *There's a chance, there's still time.*

The ref threw his arm, open palmed, out towards Etheria's try line. They had the advantage as Bow scooped up the ball and made a beeline in the other direction to the ref's hand, toward the enemy try line. Adora turned on her studs, following close behind and to the side of Bow, trying not to think of the big digital display ticking closer and closer to the 80th minute, or the 5 points that Etheria was behind the other team. She was trying to not think about who she had seen sat next to Glimmer and the others, jumping up into a cheer, her tail flicking and the late afternoon sun flashing in her blue and yellow eyes. She was trying to not think of the glances she had snuck in between plays, and how her heart had jumped every time she saw Catra still really, really there. She shook her head clear as she and Bow cleared

through the disarray of the other team's line. "Bow, I'm with you!" she called out as the fullback bore down on them. Bow popped the ball off to the side with a nimble grace, as the fullback slammed into him, it landed perfectly in Adora's open arms.

She felt still so far from their try line. She willed everything into her legs and charged as she heard the whistle go one more time, marking the start of over time. *We've only got this left.* Her legs burned and ached from the match and the effort she was asking of them now, the sound of her opponents coming up behind her urged her onwards. She was right by the painted white line as someone crashed into her from her behind. *Too late* she smirked, before their combined weight slammed them into the mud. Adora's arm, holding the ball, stretched over the try line and had firmly planted it there and she grinned as she heard the ref's whistle cry out again, this time marking her try. They would at least draw now, the scoreboard ticked over to mark her success, an even 25 to 25. If Bow could convert it though… she extracted herself from her tackler and hopped up onto her feet. Her team was around her patting her on the back as she pulled the opposing fullback back to their feet. As Bow picked up the ball and they all walked back to watch him kick for it, Adora saw that she'd landed fairly wide of the posts, it'd be a fairly narrow kick for most. However, not for Bow. His kicks were as perfect as his passes, and as the other team dashed out from their tryline, the ball soared perfectly between the posts. The full-time whistle blew as the scoreboard ticked over to HOME: 27 – AWAY: 25.

Etheria University, spectators and team, exploded. Adora dashed forwards with the team and hoisted Bow up onto her shoulders as they all hooted and hollered. When sanity eventually returned to them, they walked among their opponents shaking hands and nodding. The cheers and shouting from the stands carried them back towards the tunnel to the changing rooms. Adora looked up to where Catra was and waved at her when she found her. Catra's big energetic wave back made Adora laugh. When she looked back where she was going, Bow was ahead of her, smirking, an eyebrow raised in a laugh. Adora shoved his shoulder but laughed with him.

The locker rooms were old, draughty, and cold. It sucked before the match but now, when she was hot, sweaty, and muddy, it was a relief. They sat and cooled off as Coach (how she had introduced herself) rattled through her points, congratulating them one their good work, pointing out their weaknesses that they were going to work over. Most of the feedback was good, Adora felt, and she was glad about how quickly this team gelled, only three matches, but three victories so far. "So, now… Player of the Match." Coach's gruff voice continued "For their support in plays, always being there ready to receive, and for their tackle game, the Player of the Match is… Adora! Well done." The team cheered, and Scorpia next to her slapped her on the shoulder. "Right now, get showered, you all stink." Coach chuckled and left.

"Hey, smelly." Catra greeted her in the parking lot as the team filed out of the small stadium, bumping shoulders with her as she joined in her step. She had been waiting with Glimmer, Perfuma, and Sea Hawk and Mermista.

"I showered!" Adora protested, bumping Catra's shoulder back. "Glad to see you could make it."

"Mhm, sure you did, and yeah I threatened boss man I'd quit if he didn't move my shift. He was too scared to lose me, he needs me riding that checkout."

"So, you actually just had it free, yeah?"

"Shut up!" Catra shoved her, cackling. "You're pretty good, y'know, I think I get the hype about you finally" Catra smirked up at her after a beat.

"Oh gee, thanks so much." Adora chuckled back. She looked Catra up and down as they walked, she didn't remember when they started holding hands. "Hey, you stole my jacket."

"Yeah, it's comfy. Sue me" Catra stuck her tongue out at Adora. Adora just smiled. It had been a few weeks since she'd been back now, with plenty of classes and rugby practice away

from Catra but, outside of that, they'd swung into the old rhythm. Adora hadn't been happier since before she'd left. She knew she had made the right call coming back, in ignoring the Dean's pleas and deals to have her stay. It felt bad to lie to Catra, but how do you tell someone you abandoned that you uprooted your whole life to come back to them? It didn't matter, she was back now, and Catra's hand was in her own.

"Hey guys!" Bow's voice called out from behind. Adora and Catra stopped to look back. "Most people are gonna peel off, but we" he gestured to Glimmer and the rest of the 'Best Friend Squad' as he called them "were thinking of going to a bar? Celebration drinks?" Adora looked to Catra who shrugged.

"Yeah! Sounds good." Adora answered.

The bar in question was close to campus, nestled in a row of brick buildings. The inside was cheery. Large round booths lined the walls, and an array of mismatched tables and chairs were scattered throughout the floor. It was about as busy as any bar would be at 5pm on a Saturday but they managed to steal a booth as some patrons left. Catra laid her tail across Adora's legs as they sat next to each other and Adora hoped that the lights were low enough that no one saw her blush. Sea Hawk got everyone's orders and headed up to the bar with Mermista. They returned with trays of glasses and a few platters of wings for the table (for Scorpia and Adora). Adora, Bow, and Scorpia took turns toasting each other for their prowess on the field and the others all raised their glasses with them. Catra nudged her in the ribs lightly when Scorpia called "Cheers to the Player of the Match".

The drinks kept coming, everyone taking their turns going up and buying the round. Sea Hawk and Mermista disappeared off after Mermista bought the second round, they said they had plans early tomorrow. When Catra got up to go get her round she took Scorpia with her to help her with the trays, insisting Adora rested comfy after her match. She flicked Adora the face with the tip of her tail as she went, though, making her splutter. Not long after she was gone, Adora heard the clunking of

the jukebox in the corner as someone put on a new song. The first opening synthy notes jerked Adora's head up. The jukebox was on the other side of the bar from them, and Scorpia leaning on the bar covered her view. *Together in Electric Dreams* Adora was sure, as the song continued. Her memory was flashing through so much. Hearing it for the first time with Catra, screaming along in the back of her foster mom's car, how she had it on repeat, crying, in her lonely dorm. *We'll always be together* the song promised *Yeah, and I broke that. However far it seemed*. She was craning her neck to her see who was at the jukebox when Catra heading to the bar from what looked like the toilets stole her attention. She was tipsy swaying and bopping with the song, her tail flicking in rhythm. *Is she remembering? Is she thinking how I tore us apart?*

"Hey, you ok?" Glimmer's voice snapped her back to the table.

"Yeah… just… this song." Adora didn't know if she should say, but the weight was so much. She had to say it to someone at some point. The truth that had brought her home. She looked "It was me and Catra's favourite."

"You and Catra, huh?" Bow asked, eyebrow cocked, smirking. "You two are… *close*?" Adora looked at him wide eyed.

"No uh no not like that." Adora shook her head, turning her eyes down to the table. There was a disarray of empty glasses in front of her. "We're just friends. Best friends"

"Could've fooled me." It was Perfuma's turn for the shocked, wide eyes from Adora. She just smiled at her. "You're not bad in classes; you're doing great on the field. I don't think your scholarship fell through at all."

"No… it didn't." Adora said. *Not to the right person, idiot.* "I.." she paused and swallowed hard. "I missed her too much. I had to come home"

"You love her" accused Glimmer, with a smile.

"I love her." Adora admitted. "I love her so much. I always have. I just figured out too late."

"You should tell her" suggested Perfuma.

"I can't. I only just got back. We're just getting to know each other again." *Liar. Neither of you have changed.* The others didn't believe her either, judging by their faces. "Ok, ok. It's not that. It's just… I don't want to lose what we have. I'm so happy to be her best friend again."

Bow started to say something, but Glimmer nudged him quiet. Catra and Scorpia returned a moment later, arms laden with trays. They put the drinks down on the table, and Catra slid in next to Adora again and bumped her head lightly against Adora's shoulder. "Someone put on my favourite song." She murmured to Adora.

"Mine too, what a coincidence." Adora smiled at Catra, who giggled tipsily in response. "I think this is my last drink, by the way."

"Hmm, me too, another coincidence." Catra giggled. "You must be tired." They said their farewells, after finishing their drinks and, as they were leaving, Adora looked back to see Glimmer mouthing "tell her!" at her. She shook her head, with a smile.

The walk back to their dorm was short, lit by streetlights and accompanied by Catra humming the chorus of Electric Dreams. Adora took Catra's hand as soon as they had left the bar. Neither of them had to talk, Adora was just happy to be next to her. Their dorm was pitch dark when they got in. Adora flicked on the lamp on her bedside table, and they changed into their pyjamas in its glow. Spurred on by the alcohol still in her system, Adora yanked Catra into a hug before letting her get into bed. Catra almost shrieked, but Adora revelled in how immediately

it turned into purring. She looked down, in the hug, to see Catra looking up at her. Bathed in the amber halo of the bedside light, She was as perfect as ever. Her wild hair flopped this way and that around her face. Her eyes were hooded and sleepy and a soft smile played across her lips. Adora could feel her heart beating heavy and high in her chest, and she could feel Catra's beat in time. *God I want to kiss her.* The thought came unbidden, but she let it stay there in her mind.

"G'night Catra." Adora breathed, eventually.

"G'night, dummy." Catra replied, her smile widening a little. Barely enough sanity remained to her that she pulled away then, before she did something rash.

They crawled into their own beds and as Adora reached to turn off her light she took part in her nighttime ritual, looking over to see Catra, eyes closed, smiling softly and continuing to purr.

Chapter 5

Chapter Notes

This is one of the chapters im least confident is any good lol, enjoy!

Catra

"Why did I play that stupid song!?" Catra nearly screamed, pushing her sorcery work away. The runes and sigils had been meaningless when she opened the book, and they were simply impossible now. She was sat at her desk with Scorpia next to her. They were supposed to be helping each other with the work that Shadow Weaver had set them, but Catra knew she had been useless. She'd spent the entirety of the last hour as she had the past week, remembering the clunk of the jukebox as it slotted the old record into the player, remembering Adora looking so uncomfortable talking to the others, remembering how she'd wanted to leave immediately. *You're such an idiot, what even was your plan?*

"Whoah, hey?" Scorpia jerked back, off of leaning on her hand. She'd definitely been almost asleep. "Song? Oh, from the bar?"

"Yeah. From the bar." Catra had stood from the desk and was pacing now. *It wasn't all bad.* She remembered how they'd held each other before bed. *That doesn't make it BETTER!* She could have kissed her, they were so close, it would just have been a little lift on her toes and… *STOP! You nearly blew it all up!* "What was I thinking, Scorpia?"

"You were thinking you love her!" Scorpia knew, Scorpia had figured it out before Catra had, just from how Catra had told her about Adora in freshman year. She'd said as much at Glimmer's party. "You were just testing the waters. You were pretty buzzed too, take it easy on yourself." Scorpia smiled her big warm smile and clapped the Sorcery book shut; it fizzled lightly. "It's not as bad as you think, I promise."

"So, why's she been so 'busy' this week then?" The old, framed, polaroid on her desk stole her focus, as it so often did, as she paced by the desk. "Working on her costume? How elaborate is it?" Glimmer was throwing a Halloween party that night, the invites had gone out the day after the match and bar, Adora had

jumped on the chance. Catra… not so much. She'd not replied either which way yet. Parties meant a lot of people, who she didn't know, and probably didn't want to. *Adora will be there*.

"Yeah, working on her costume. She says what she means, Catra." Scorpia's tone was as stern as she could make it, meaning not very stern at all, but it did chide Catra a little. "Glimmer and Perfuma have been helping her. You never said if you were gonna go by the way."

"I wasn't gonna."

"Wasn't? Changed your mind?" *Maybe? Adora will be there.*

"I don't really like them. Too much noise, too many people" Catra's ears flicked. "I can't think, I get uncomfortable."

"But, Adora will be there, right?" *Adora will be there.*

"Yeah, right… Adora will be there." Catra did know what she had been thinking at the bar. She'd been thinking it for a little bit now. She had to tell Adora what she felt. She'd tried to wrap it up, bottle it, but to no avail. The song was testing the waters, Scorpia was right, and the cold shock had terrified Catra. Adora's face at the booth swam in her mind's eye, furtive eyes, nearly grimacing. *You made her uncomfortable, idiot. You'll just make her uncomfortable again.* Scorpia said it wasn't that bad, though… a*m I being stupid? What if telling her ruins it all? I just…* "I don't have a costume or anything." *I have to tell her.*

"We can sort that!" Scorpia pushed out of her chair with surprising speed. "There's still a little time" she grabbed Catra's hand in a vice grip and yanked her towards the door. Catra shrieked.

Adora

Huntara's Gym wasn't the fanciest place in the world. The equipment was old, mismatched, and often spotted with rust here and there, but it was all plenty good enough. It was close to campus, too, which had sold Adora on it more than anything. Bow had discovered it and he, Scorpia, and Adora often trained there. Insanely, when she'd turned up a few weeks after they started going, they'd found out that the Huntara of Huntara's Gym was their very own Coach. She'd laughed her gruff laugh when she'd seen them and told them that her teams often found themselves at her gym, she'd been glad to see them there. Adora was very glad to be there now. The gym was one of her favourite places to work through emotions, and she needed to work through them quickly, before the party. Her phone was lying on top of her gym bag, by the chest press she was on, the message still proudly displayed there. It had come a few minutes ago, as Adora was loading up her final exercise. Next to Perfuma's little profile picture. "Scorpia says Catra's gonna come!"

She grabbed the handles of the press and got back to work. The loaded plates clanked and clattered as the arms of the machine moved but her own mind was far louder. *Catra's coming, she's going to be there.* Catra had dodged the question every time she'd asked in the week. *Ok, ok, ok you can do it. This is the time.* She should have told her a week ago, as they'd held each other. *We'll always be together, just like our song says.* Glimmer, Bow, and Perfuma had sworn themselves to secrecy, but they'd talked about it among themselves plenty as they'd worked on their costume. They were sure nothing could go wrong. They were sure Adora should confess. Adora could almost believe them, almost. Too much sat heavy on Adora though. *I cannot lose her again. I cannot push her away again*. The weights clanked loudly as she finished her set and clunked the arms of the press back into place.

She unloaded the weights and put them back on their pegs, where Huntara had written the numbers in messy sharpie.

Shouldering her gym bag, she picked up her phone and texted back a quick "That's great, thanks for letting me know" to Perfuma. Bow wasn't there, he was helping Glimmer set up for the party. Scorpia wasn't there, she was helping Catra with work and maybe getting a costume now? She didn't think Catra had any Halloween stuff. There was no one to talk to, no one to psych her up. Coach… Huntara was sat at the front desk, pretending to type things into a spreadsheet, but Adora couldn't lump her crap on her. No, she just needed to go get ready now.

"Hey, Adora. Wait up" Huntara surprised Adora as she walked by the front, to the door. Adora stopped. "I don't know what's in your head, and I ain't gonna ask, but I can tell something's up." She stood and walked to Adora, clapping her on a shoulder. "You got this, kid. You're tough, you can do it."

"Thanks, Coach, I hope you're right" Adora smiled weakly at her.

"I am. Now get out. Go get it done" She shoved Adora towards the door.

Catra

"We're late…" the music was thumping beyond the walls of Glimmer's suburban palace, lights blazed through the windows despite the curtains shut to the world. *She's really gone all out, huh.* At the huge wood door Catra was next to the most ripped Harley Quinn the world had ever seen. *Scorpia looks great. Her costume is so well made. Not like…* she looked down at the cheap vampire costume they had found. The last thing in her size, the cons of buying a Halloween costume on the day of. They'd augmented it with a cheap masquerade mask, and she'd shoved her hair into a bushy ponytail. *Nothing gonna hide these ears, or tail.* Something had made her desperate to not be recognised. Scorpia hadn't got it, but she had tried to help. The plastic vampire teeth were on Scorpia's insistence *I've already got pointy teeth…* but she'd not backed down. Catra felt so stupid. *Adora is in there.*

Catra took a deep breath and stepped up to the door. The big handle and latch was cold in her hand. The door was heavy as she opened it into the big open foyer. The noise blasted out in a shockwave and Catra nearly stopped right there. After another deep breath, and a hand on the shoulder from Scorpia, they stepped onto the hardwood and swung the door shut behind them. The living room to the side was packed, sat on the couches, the coffee table, standing about. People were dashing through the foyer carrying red solo cups from the kitchen. *Is that the goddamn Monster Mash? This is a cliché!* The costumes Catra saw weren't much better. A sexy nurse here, a sexy nun there. *Quite a few people wearing cat ears though, useful.* In a flash of light, Glimmer was in front of her and Scorpia.

"Hey guys! You made it!" she screamed over the music. She was dressed like Princess Leia, in her cool combat fatigues from Endor. *Hell yeah. Means Bow is Han somewhere.* "I like your costumes!"

"Thanks!" Scorpia yelled back. "Have you seen Perfuma!?"

“Yeah, Poison Ivy is downstairs! I think the others are with her! Now, sorry! I gotta go mingle!” she was gone in another flash of light. Catra still was not used to it.

“I’m gonna go get a drink” Catra went on her tiptoes to say to Scorpia. She didn’t feel like yelling. Scorpia nodded and went off down the stairs to the basement. The corridor by the side of the stairs was blocked off with a big X of police tape spattered with fake blood. The kitchen was open, though just as decorated. Ranks of bats and ghosts and skeletons hung from the ceiling and the floor and surfaces were scattered with arrays of jack-o-lanterns of different sizes. It wasn’t too busy in the kitchen and Catra didn’t recognise anyone here. *Thank God.* She went over and sniffed the big bowl of punch. The unmistakable tang of vodka stung her sensitive nose. *Thank God.* She grabbed a cup from the big plastic tube and filled it to the brim. Then again a moment later. *You need to go find her.*

Adora

It was quieter in the basement, and less boiling. The press of people in the living room had turned it into an oven. Adora also knew the people down here. Mermista was on one of the sofas, playing with Sea Hawk's hair as he rested his head in her lap. She was a fancy detective Adora didn't recognise, and Sea Hawk was… Sea Hawk frankly, and he'd already had too much to drink. Perfuma was an incredible Poison Ivy sat next to Han Solo Bow. They were both playing that fighting game with some people from the team. There were other people down here, taking a break from the noise too, Kyle from History was sat leaning against the wall nodding his head lightly to the music that made its way down the stairs. Adora was leaning against the bar, nursing a less than quarter full solo cup of rum and coke. Another perk of the basement was being able to choose your own drink. She had drunk too much too fast, though not as much as Sea Hawk, trying to steady her courage. Glimmer had disappeared off, citing the door opening. *Is she here? Am I ready?*

Movement by the stairs snapped Adora's attention, the speed of her head moving spun her brain a little. Harley Quinn Scorpia was coming down, eyes scanning for Perfuma. *Just Scorpia.* Scorpia waved at her and pointed up the stairs, in the direction of the kitchen. It looked like she said, "getting a drink". Adora nodded at her and mouthed "thank you". *Do I go to her, do I wait until she comes to me?* She tried to steady her breathing. She looked to her cup and downed what was in it, more rum than coke it tasted. She shoved off the bar and made her way, with purpose though swaying a little, towards the stairs. *I need to be confident. Funny, She likes my jokes. It will be ok. I'm tough. I've got this. I'm tough. I've got this.*

Catra

Her fourth punch had disappeared, shortly before her fifth, but she'd finally put the cup down. *Ok, that's enough Dutch courage. Go get her tiger.* The kitchen had nearly emptied out. The only people left were some guy leaning against the cold sliding glass doors to the back yard, clearly snoring, and her, still leaning against the kitchen island. Not moving. Still not moving. *What is wrong with you!? Go!!* She took a few quick breaths and pushed herself away from the island, she stumbled a little as she came to a stop. She turned slowly to the left and started towards the door to the foyer. Focusing on one foot in front of another she walked into a wall that was where she thought the door was, but the wall reached down and caught her and pulled her close. Catra looked up… and there was She-Ra! Glowing purple, then orange, then gold in the lights flashing out of the living room behind her. Her bare arm held Catra close, safely, tightly. *Adora!* Catra's heart thudded hard and felt like it might stop. The costume was perfect. Adora looked like she'd come straight out of one of her comic books. She was beautiful. *She* was perfect. Catra tried to speak but her mouth just hung open.

"Hey, careful there." Adora broke the silence. She didn't speak loudly but Catra heard her clearly over whatever was playing. "You've not seen my roommate anywhere have you? Ears like yours…"

Your roommate? I'm right here? Catra's voice still would not come to her.

"Cute costume… Cat Dracula?"

"Y-yeah." Catra finally manged. "Your She-Ra is amazing."

"You recognise her? No one else here did." Adora smirked a little. Catra's heart thudded again. *Of course I'd recognise She-Ra. Does she not know it's me? Maybe the mask did work?* She didn't know why she'd wanted to hide behind it, but now she wished it wasn't

on at all. She reached up to take it off, but as her hands brushed Adora's hips they just stopped and rested there. The punch was fuzzing Catra's head, the world was shrinking and shrinking as Adora's strong arm continued to hold her close. All Catra could see was Adora's face looking down at her, Adora's face leaning down towards her, all she could hear was their breathing in rhythm. She felt herself lift on her toes.

Suddenly their lips were pressed together, and the world disappeared. All Catra knew was Adora, her hands running up Adora's sides, feeling the muscle there under the thinness of her costume. She was breathless and panting as they broke apart and leaned in to join again, and again. Her hands found Adora's head and held her there, she felt her legs wrap around Adora and Adora's strong arms pull their bodies closer together. Catra could taste the rum on Adora's breath, on her tongue. Adora made a low sound in her throat as she ran her hands through Catra's hair, pulling it out of the ponytail, it fell in messy curtains around them surrounding their passion, hiding the rest of the world. Catra surfaced for air, panting, pressing her forehead to Adora's as Adora pressed her up against a wall. Adora kept planting little kisses on her as Catra kept her eyes closed, revelling. She had started purring at some point, and Adora trailing her lips along her jaw, kissing lightly as she went, only made it louder.

"Let's go somewhere, Dracula." Adora whispered, kissing below Catra's ear. *Dracula…* suddenly it all came crashing around Catra. *She's not kissing **me**, she's just kissing. She's just drunk.* Tears welled as her eyes opened. Adora had her head buried in Catra's neck, pressing her lips lightly to her. It was wrong. She was here to tell Adora she loved her but instead she'd just jumped her like some horny stranger. Her eyes began to sting.

"I'm sorry" Catra sputtered out. She shoved to the side, breaking away from Adora, stumbling as she landed on the kitchen floor. "I'm so sorry" She turned and ran at the front door.

Adora called something behind her, but Catra burst ought of the house and ran and ran. The tears began to fall as the cold shock

of the late October air met her. She'd lost the vampire's cape at some point, but she ignored it. Her feet pounded against the concrete.

She didn't hear Adora call her name out from the house.

Chapter 6

Adora

Rain crashed down around them in thick, cold, sheets. The ball had been rendered slick and the ground made a morass in the downpour, but Adora could hardly blame the conditions, or Bow's pass, as it tumbled forward out of her arms. The whistle blew as she swore and kicked at the mud below her. She slumped into her position as the forwards set up for the scrum. Once again Scorpia, the backbone of their scrum, was immovable as the ball was put in. Scorpia… *"I'm sorry for everything"* the note had said, pen on post it, stuck to her desk a yellow accusation *"I'm going to stay with Scorpia and Perfuma." What did she have to be sorry for?* Adora burned *I'm the one who fucked it.* She could still feel Catra in her arms, see her face in front of her, remembering how she'd leaned down to her, remembering the tears in Catra's eyes as she'd pushed away. *You fucking idiot.*

She barely reacted in time as the other team's centre tried to dash past her. She tackled him way too high, nearly around the neck. Whistle, yellow card. Adora stared at it sticking into the air in the ref's hand, blazing in the floodlights. *"I'm sorry for everything"* the note had said, black on yellow. She walked to the sidelines without complaint. The sin bin was where she belonged. The floodlights obscured the stands as she approached. She didn't need to see though. She knew Glimmer was there for Bow, Perfuma for Scorpia, umbrellas and raincoats. *She's not here,* she knew. She knew. She was the one who had sent her away. A part of Adora was almost glad for the lonely dugout she slumped into. She couldn't see the score; she couldn't see the stands. She was free to hold her head in her hands and stare at the ground.

"Adora," Coach Huntara's gruff voice shook her. She was stood in front of her, leaning on the edge of the dugout, her face was stoney looking down at Adora. "I'm sending Lonnie on for you when your time's up."

"Yep, ok."

"No arguing?" Adora just shook her head. The team would be better served by Lonnie. She wouldn't mess it all up. Huntara sat heavily on the bench next to Adora. "What's up, kid?"

Her eyes stung as she tried to figure out what to say. "You weren't right." Adora choked out, refusing to look away from the ground. "I didn't have it. I screwed it up."

"Nothing's unfixable, broken forever." She laid a hand on Adora's shoulder, reassuring. "You can fix it with her." Adora looked up shocked. Huntara laughed. "I've seen you looking at the stands, I ain't stupid." Huntara stood and moved to the stairs out of the dugout. "You're important to this team, Adora. I'll give you this match, but I'm not benching you for good. Keep your head in the game. It'll help."

You're wrong again, Adora thought at Huntara's back. She'd tried to fix it before, that was why she was here at all. She was incapable of doing what was right for Catra. *The fucking scholarship, the fucking kiss.* Catra's hair had been silk in her hands, messy around them, she had been soft and perfect, and she had cried as she ran away. Adora shook her head, trying to snap the memories out. She'd ran after her, but Catra always had been faster. Their dorm had been empty the next day, and the next, until that note. *"I'm going to stay with Scorpia and Perfuma."* Scorpia was why Adora had even come to this match at all. She'd been staring at her phone all week, opened to Catra's messages, starting to type then deleting it all, over and over. Scorpia had been with Catra before the party, Catra was staying with Scorpia. She had felt she needed to talk to her. *And say what, ask what?* She raged at herself *"Yeah, you messed up, again. Yeah, she wasn't ready for that"* that's what it would be, all it could be. *You fucked everything. Again.* What was the point? She'd screwed up in the match, she was a screw up, what could she possibly learn from Scorpia? She shouldn't have come.

The rest of the match went by at a snail's pace. When the final whistle blew, Adora didn't know which side was cheering. She was back in the locker room before the rest of the team, and she left

before everyone else, not bothering with the shower or even changing out of her rain soaked kit. There wasn't any point in staying, talking, anything. The early dark of November cocooned her as she walked back to her dorm. The rain had relented but the thick clouds remained, leaving the sky starless. Not that she would have noticed if they were there, anyway. *You wanted to* ***talk*** *to her.* Adora wanted to scream. She had been ragged breathing, the taste of punch, a tail disappearing into the night, a cape left on a kitchen floor. Adora all but fell onto the bench she had found herself next to, once again cradling her head in her hands. She let the tears flow freely, this far from anyone.

"Adora?" a voice roused her. She didn't know how long she'd been on that bench; she'd cried until she couldn't any longer and then just stayed there. She was freezing. Dr. Micah stood over her, concern laced across his face.

"Dr. Mike?"

"Glimmer and Bow lost you after the match, you weren't at your dorm." He sat next to her and wrapped a thick jacket around her shoulders. "Bow said you'd left your bag and stuff in the locker rooms. They were worried." Adora looked about her. She recognised none of it. This was not the way to her dorm.

"I'm sorry. I didn't mean to worry anyone." Adora's voice was shaky and raw. She stood quickly and started walking away. "Thanks, I'll just go back to my room now."

"It's the other way, Adora." Dr. Micah stood up and locked step next to her as she turned. "I'm walking you there. They'll want to know you're back safe." He already had his phone in his hands, Adora could see Glimmer's profile picture at the top of the screen. They walked in silence, Micah guiding her back to campus. She was grateful for the jacket.

"Listen," Micah said when they'd reached her door "Maybe this isn't for me to say, or know about, but I saw you and Catra

reunite day one.” *God everyone fucking knows!?* “I don’t know what happened between you two, but it isn’t the end.”

“Yeah, thanks, sure.” She just wanted to be alone now. She wanted to scream again. She thrust the jacket back at him and quickly got through her door, shutting it in Micah’s face. *Don’t they get it!? It has to be the end!* She looked to where the polaroid stood on Catra’s desk. *I just keep breaking her.*

Adora curled into a ball on the floor. Turned away from Catra’s bed. Her tears had come again as she failed to banish the memories. *I never should have come back.*

Chapter 7

Catra

November had slipped into December, the last dregs of the month fading away in bleak greyness. The cold and rainy days given way to frigid dryness. The semester was nearly over. The bright high sky, streaked with wispy clouds, along with the gaudy and flashing decorations of the neighbours were hidden away by the tightly shut blinds and curtains in Scorpia's spare room. Catra lay in the twin bed, curled under the thick duvet, turned away from the window. It was well past midday, and it would be further still before she moved, she was sure. At first she had tried to keep up as if things were normal, going to classes, talking to anyone, but that had drifted fast. She wasn't even crying anymore; she didn't think she had any tears left. Her routine had become simple; wake up, think about Adora, feel the stabbing in her heart, try to sleep, dream about her, repeat. She felt pathetic, broken, useless… and it was all so familiar.

But this time it's your fault. She rolled over in the bed, tucking her head further into the tight hold of her arms. *Why did you do it?* She had run over Halloween night countless times in her mind. Adora's strong arm holding her close, her perfect face gazing down at her, haloed in the lights of Glimmer's party. *She was looking for you and you just jumped her*. In the days afterwards she had watched as, countless times, the three little dots would appear by Adora's name, only to disappear again. No messages had come. Catra knew what they would have been anyway. *"What the hell, Catra, that wasn't ok." "That was too far, it's not like that between us."* Eventually it had stopped, Adora's messages had become inactive, nothing new, no three dots. She had given up on Catra again. *And you deserve it*.

Catra sighed and grimaced as the twisting agony came back again, same as every day. It would pass, again, eventually. It had last time. *You didn't know you loved her then.* Her heart twisted harder. Her sigh turned into a growl; she forced herself out of the bed landing on all fours on the floor strewn with her stuff. *It's your own damn fault.* Straightening herself out she saw

the clock on her phone, nestled on the bedside table, reading too deep into the afternoon to be reasonable. *You need to get a grip. You need to make it pass.* She pawed through her clothes and pulled on something, anything, and turned to the door. She steeled herself for the apartment outside it. Bright and cheery, like Scorpia and Perfuma always were. They had been good to her while she stayed in their apartment. Scorpia was on the team with Adora but had been careful talking around her when Catra was about. They deserved better than to have Catra rotting away in their spare room. She turned the handle and almost walked into Scorpia outside the door. She was standing, hand raised, like she was about to knock.

"Oh! Hey, Catra." Scorpia dropped her arm down by her side. "I was just gonna come talk to you."

"About what?" Catra asked, her tone worse than she intended, her voice croaky and dry.

"So, uh, Glimmer just messaged about a couple things. She says, um, Adora has gone to stay with them if you want your dorm back." Catra barely reacted as the name twisted her insides. *Leaving again…* "and of course, you don't have to go, she actually said that a little bit ago I just um, y'know, I didn't want to upse- and of course you can stay as long as you want, we're more than happy, we just thought maybe- "

"Scorpia, it's fine." Catra tried to mean it. She already knew that anyway; Glimmer had messaged her too. Catra had left her on read and thrown her phone across the room. The prospect of the dorm had burned at her, she couldn't face it. Maybe that was what she needed. *You need to make it pass.* "I should go back; you guys have been too kind. What else did Glimmer message about?"

"Oh, well, she's doing a last party before the holidays this weekend and wanted to make sure you knew you were invited! A just the squad kinda thing"

"Don't think I'll go, but thanks, and thank her too." Catra tried to smile at Scorpia.

"Well, check your phone and thank her yourself!" Scorpia beamed her big grin.

"Sure, sure…" Catra turned back into the room. She wasn't sure what she had intended to do, leaving it, but now she had a goal. Pack and go home, her own dorm. *You need to make it pass.* She swung the door behind her and heard Scorpia walk away a few moments later. She diligently ignored her phone as she stuffed what little clothes and stuff she had brought into the little rucksack she had brought it in. Scorpia offered her a ride and she accepted, sitting in the passenger seat in silence. The last time she had been in Scorpia's car was on Halloween and she was desperately trying and failing to not think about that. She was trying to not think about those few seconds of perfection, again. Adora's smile, the way she had held her, the way she had kissed along her jaw, Adora's hands in her hair. She tried to not think about how Adora ran, face hardened with determination, in her matches, or how her hand felt in Catra's own, or how her laugh made Catra feel like she could explode, or how Adora made her feel worthwhile. *You have to make it pass.*

The little whiteboard on the dorm room door sent another twist of pain through her. Where, before, it was them both, now it just read Catra's name. She wiped away the little evil smiley she had drawn there as she opened the door. The inside was a stark reminder of freshman year. There was her bed and desk, messy as she had left it, but the other side was bare. The bed lay empty, with the bedding stripped and folded neatly in the centre. The posters they had bought no longer covered the walls on that side. *She-Ra gone from my life again.* No books or folders were spread across Adora's desk, the seat tucked below like no one had ever sat there at all. Except… a folded piece of paper in the dead centre of the desk "Catra" written on its face. Everything dragged her towards it, but Catra fought. She unpacked her rucksack, dumping the clothes into her laundry basket.

She sat on her bed, cross-legged against the wall, and finally checked her phone. As she expected there were emails about her lack of attendance, her failure to hand in assignments. A message from Glimmer about this weekend's party that she just swiped away the notification for, there was no way she could go if that was where Adora was staying. Apart from that, though, there was nothing. A blank phone with a blank background, a crack running from one corner to the other. Better that than the selfie that Adora had taken of them when she had swiped Catra's phone. *You have to make it pass.* She closed her phone and let it drop to the bed. She let her eyes rove across the room again. The polaroid was still on her desk, even if she could only see the back of the frame from where she was sat. A part of her wanted to reach over and throw it hard against the wall, get rid of it for good, but instead she looked towards the folded paper on what had been Adora's desk. Curiosity was getting the better of her, and Adora deserved to have it read. To have Catra face whatever admonition lay within. She shoved off her bed and picked it up. Unfolding it revealed a little wall of Adora's neat writing.

"Catra,

I've thought about how to say this in a thousand ways and a thousand times, but nothing ever seems to be right. I'm not brave enough to say this in person. So let me just say: I'm sorry.

I'm sorry for how I behaved at the party, I'm sorry for making you uncomfortable. I'm sorry I keep fucking up and pushing us away from each other.

You mean more to me than I can easily put into words. I understand that you don't want to be around me, and that's ok, you shouldn't. I've gone to Glimmer's and will stay out of your way.

Just know, I am so, so sorry and you will always be my best friend. Even if we never talk again. However far it seems.

Adora."

Catra stared open mouthed at the note for a while. She reread it a few times as the twisting pain that had been her companion since Halloween changed and was replaced with something burning, shooting, white hot through her. *However far it seems, however far it seems*. That song, *their song,* reverberated around her head. Thundering with her heart. *Adora's sorry!? Fuck I am such an idiot!* The white hot hammering resolved into flashes, insight, memory. The feeling of Adora's hand in hers, how the world had frozen as they had kissed. Her mantra changed in an instant. *You have to fix this.* She folded the paper again and strode to her bed and grabbed her phone. Opening it to Glimmer's message she started typing.

"Hey! A party sounds great, I think. Count me in."

Chapter 8

Chapter Notes

See the end of the chapter for notes

Adora

Thud, thud, thud, thud-thud. The slamming of wrapped fists against the leather bag was barely audible under the music, noise really, pounding through Adora's headphones. She could not allow any thoughts or feelings to take hold. She focused on the grinding guitar and smashing drums, and the sharp numbness creeping up from her knuckles. When she'd first picked this up a few weeks ago she had considered printing her own face out to tape to the bag and tonight it had been especially tempting. She couldn't hide away in her room in Glimmer's house, so here she was. She'd half-heartedly joked to Glimmer that she was going to punch out her feelings, but it wouldn't help, she knew. It was an excuse, a distraction. The party was probably underway at Glimmer's and every fibre of her being wanted to be there, to get down on her knees and beg Catra's forgiveness. Huntara's Gym echoed with the tattoo of the failure that she beat into the punching bag.

Catra doesn't want to talk to you, her fist slammed into the leather, *you fucked up bad this time.* Catra had been silent since Halloween, and Scorpia had said nothing of what she might know. Besides, Adora had made a promise to keep out of Catra's way, and she would damn well keep it. *She doesn't want your apologies,* her other hand beat at the image of her own face swimming in her mind. Adora had been glad to hear Catra would be coming to Glimmer's party, then she remembered her promise. Catra had definitely read the note she had left, Scorpia had said she'd gone back to the dorm, she wouldn't expect, or want, to see Adora there. So, she had made herself scarce. *Like a coward.* Her lungs were beginning to burn as she kept at the bag. It was good Catra wanted to be with the others, though, she deserved good friends. Her next punch went astray and slid sideways off of the leather, lurching her forwards, her shoulder slamming into the bag. She let her arms wrap around it as her head mashing knocked her headphones askew off of her ears. She didn't know when she had started crying, but now she could hear it in the silence of the near empty gym.

“You’re gonna hurt yourself punching like that.” Huntara’s gruff voice called from off to the side somewhere.

“Good.” Adora’s eyes were shut firm as she leaned into the bag.

“Alright, kid, that’s enough of that.” Adora felt a strong hand pull her away from the bag. Opening her eyes she saw Huntara at her side. “Take those wraps off, no more punishing yourself.” Adora blithely started unwrapping her hands, there was rarely any point arguing. “I, once again, do not want to get in your business… but this is going on too long.” Adora shrugged, looking away from her, dropping her wraps into her gym bag. *Maybe it is.* It didn’t matter if it was, she’d made a promise. She would not hurt Catra again.

“Sure, coach.”

“Don’t give me that crap, Adora. You’re a fighter, on the pitch, with this bag” Huntara gave it a shove. “I don’t think you *want* to give up like this.”

“Whatever.” Adora just shrugged her letterman jacket back on and hoisted up her gym bag. Huntara nearly growled in a sigh of frustration before just stomping away. Adora felt her phone buzz in her jacket pocket. *Probably Glimmer pissed at me disappearing.* She hadn’t told anyone she wasn’t going to be there; it was easier that way. She yanked her phone out of the pocket and, sure enough, emblazoned over her background of… *no ignore it*, there were notifications from Glimmer, Bow, and… *Catra!?* She felt as if her heart stopped beating.

“I thought you were going to be here” was all it said. Suddenly her heart was beating all too fast, and all too high. *I’m being a fucking idiot*. The other messages were simple, a “Hey, where are you?” from Bow, and similar from Glimmer but accompanied with “Catra’s here!” into “She wanted to talk to you” a little bit later, and then… “Catra’s left. Go get her NOW!” Adora’s heart nearly exploded. *I’m being an idiot!* She felt her gym bag slip from her shoulder as she ran for the door, she just let it fall.

Catra, a little while earlier

"Hey, Catra! You look great!" Glimmer was as cheery as she had ever been as she pulled open the heavy door to her parents' house.

"Thanks… listen sorry I'm late, it took me longer to get ready than I thought." Catra felt almost stupid with the effort she had put into her look. It wasn't something she ever did. Makeup doesn't work well with fur and this dress was *cold* in the evening air. *It's for Adora* she reminded herself. She had wanted to look her best, whatever that meant, to talk to her. She wanted to be Catra this time, no confusions, no mistakes, no stupid plastic vampire fangs, and she wanted to be the best Catra she could be. *Is this your best Catra?* She had been second guessing herself since she left the dorm, but there was no going back now.

"Well, it was worth it! Come on in, we're all in the basement again." Glimmer let her through the door and swung it shut behind her. *Ok, ok, ok* Catra's heart was beginning to go into overdrive *this is it, time to talk. What do I say? I should have thought about that!? "Hey Adora, long time no see… again" no that's insane.* She barely noticed Glimmer tugging her down the stairs by her hand. She felt as if she might pass out more and more with each step down. The sounds of the others got louder as they went, voices and laughter, the impacts and jingles of that game again. The basement opened up below them as they descended; a low thumping beat surrounded Catra as she saw the sofas arranged around the huge flatscreen, she couldn't tell if it was the music or her heart pounding in her ears. There was Scorpia, nestled against Perfuma, watching Bow run circles around Sea Hawk and Mermista, and… there was no Adora.

"Hey… Glimmer?" she muttered over to the shock of pink in front who turned to look back at her. "Is… Adora here?" Glimmer's face went through a cavalcade of emotions, most of which Catra didn't make out, but she did see shock plain on her face at the last.

"Oh, uh… no." Glimmer's hold on her hand suddenly tightened. "She's…"

"Avoiding me, yeah I got her note." The thumping of Catra's heart was changing pace, she felt nearly sick. "Thought I was gonna surprise her here. I wanted to talk to her."

"She asked me to tell her if you were coming."

"Of course she did."

"I'm sorry, I thought-"

"It's fine" *Goddamn it Adora.* Catra dragged a stool from the basement bar over to behind the sofas and sat heavily on it. *"Stay out of my way" you are my way, dummy.* She sighed and curled her tail around herself and contented herself to watch the flashing fight unfolding on the flatscreen. It wasn't blond hair, or strong arms, or blue eyes, so it was dull, grey, meaningless. Scorpia caught her eye and gave a wave and a smile and Catra forced a smile onto her face and her ears out of the droop they had settled into. *Why are you so stubborn Adora? Why are we both?* She was thinking of their kiss, again, and of Adora's note. *She was sorry, she "made me uncomfortable", she goddamn knew.* She thought of how intense she had felt, the breathlessness, how she had thrown herself into Adora. *Can't you see how much I wanted it, wanted you?* It was futile to think it to herself. She pulled her phone out of the little bag she had brought and opened her messages to Adora.

"I thought you were going to be here" she typed and hit send. Sending. Sent. Delivered… delivered… delivered. On delivered for ten minutes. Wherever Adora was she was ignoring her phone, it seemed. *Or maybe she is done with you?* She shook her head at herself, *However far it seems, she wrote.* They had promised to not abandon each other when Adora had made the team, and they had failed, but Catra knew she was going to fix it. As time ticked on, though, with the message lying ignored, the fire Catra had felt when she read the note, and when she had

made herself up for the party, was waning, leaving behind the emptiness again in its wake. She grit her teeth against the tears that threatened to come. Too long had passed, and she had barely heard anything the others had said or seen what they were doing. Suddenly it was all too much. *If Adora isn't coming, what's the point?* She'd got herself all made up for nothing, got out of her rot for nothing. It built and built.

She pushed off the stool and padded silently to the stairs. Looking back, the others were too engrossed with the screen to see her go. She crept up the stairs and out the door into the frigid winter air.

Adora

She found Catra not far from their once shared dorm. The street was well lit against the nighttime gloam, unlike the ones Adora had been down. Trancelike, her feet pounding below her as she checked from here to there, from the gym to Glimmer's house. The bolt of conviction that had coursed through her reading Catra's message had carried her as fast as her feet could carry her, no… faster but, as she saw Catra, walking slowly away towards campus, bathed in the streetlights, she almost faltered. She was almost shuffling, arms and tail wrapped tightly around herself, Adora could hear her sniffling from where she was.

"Catra!" Adora called almost as an instinct against the nerves that were growing again, and Catra froze. *I'm not letting you down again*. "Hang on!" Catra did not move as Adora approached. She grew strangely still and would not turn, not even as Adora came to a stop behind her. The small sequins in the dress she wore shimmered as Catra let out a shuddering breath.

"You're not here. I've finally lost it" Catra's voice quivered and shook and Adora's heart almost collapsed.

"I'm really here." Adora reached a hand to Catra's shoulder but let it fall. "I promise."

"You promise!?" Catra's voice had turned into a lash, an admonition, a reminder of Adora's useless words. Just as fast as she had whipped out, though, her tone softened "I'm sorry. I'm sorry" Catra turned and Adora saw her face for the first time in forever. Her perfect eyeliner had run a little with her tears, and the way she was holding onto her own shoulders tugged at Adora, at her failures. Seeing her there, finally, again, Adora's own tears began to well.

"You look nice…" Adora nearly sputtered out. *Get it together, now.* She really did, as always. The dress nearly sparkled in the streetlights, shining better than any diamond. More than

anything, Adora could see her there, she would be perfect in any way, so long as she was there.

"You were supposed to be there."

"I should have been. Before and always." Adora took her own deep shuddering breath against the tears that now would not stop. *Fix it.* "I promised you and I failed and I'm so sor-"

"Stop it." Catra forced, stunning Adora. "We both promised, Adora, you're not taking this all on yourself."

Adora struggled to find the right thing to say. They stood there in silence, Catra sniffling and rubbing her tears with the heel of her hand, Adora just stunned. She was beginning to feel the cold a little on her face. *The cold!? Look at Catra!* That shook her up. Suddenly she was pulling off her letterman.

"Hey, you're freezing." She said, offering Catra the jacket who surprised her by taking it without fuss. "Listen, we both did promise, yeah, but…" Adora fought to find the right way to say it. Halloween was flashing though her mind again, how Catra had shoved away from her and ran and ran. "I pushed it. I got drunk and stupid; I made you uncomfortable."

"I was kissing you back, dummy." Catra nearly laughed out, pulling the jacket close around her.

"But you pushed away, you ran?"

"You called me Dracula, I thought…" now Catra was chuckling, through tears "I thought you thought I was some rando, and I felt like I'd just jumped you." *That's what it was!?* A weight disappeared from Adora's shoulders. *I was just trying to be funny; god am I an idiot.*

"Catra…"

"I read your note; I know, now, that you knew… I feel like such an idiot."

"You're not, not any more than I am. We'd both had a lot to drink." Adora remembered the taste of punch, Catra's hands on her face, her legs round her waist. "Of course, I knew it was you. I couldn't mistake you for anyone." Adora found herself reaching and holding Catra by the shoulders "and there's no one else in the world I would ever want to kiss."

Adora pulled Catra closer and tentatively rested her forehead on Catra's. Her heart leapt and soared as Catra leaned her head into Adora's and pressing herself into Adora's embrace. Both their tears had stopped as they looked into each other's eyes. The nerves were gone in Adora now, replaced only with Catra.

"I should tell you, Catra…" Adora smiled. "The scholarship never fell through. They begged me to stay."

"What!?" Catra leant back away from Adora, her eyes wide.

"I hated it there. I was alone and… you were here. Not there."

"What are you saying?"

"I came back *for you*. I love you, Catra. I always have. Just took leaving to know."

Catra stared at her, her mismatched eyes scanning Adora's blue. Then her face cracked into a wide smile.

"I love you too, Adora." Adora's heart seemed to disappear, or swell, or explode. "I knew it the minute you were back."

They rested their heads against each other again, basking in their confession, their eyes locked on one another.

"What do we do now?" Catra broke the silence.

"I don't know? Get married?"

They broke into laughter, Catra leaning into Adora's shoulder as she giggled. They stayed leaning against each other even after the laughter was gone.

"How about we get out of the cold first, you've gotta be freezing and I'm not giving this jacket back."

"That works for me."

Together

They walked back to the dorm together, Adora holding a purring Catra close by an arm wrapped around her shoulders. They both felt lighter than they had in years. They didn't say anything, they were both more than happy to be holding on to each other, stealing constant looks at each other, as they went.

When they reached the door Catra went right in, but Adora stopped and grabbed the pen nestled at the top of the little whiteboard and put her name back where it belonged, right next to Catra's, then she followed Catra in.

The bare half of the room didn't register to either of them. In the light of the desk lamp that Catra had turned on they only saw each other, golden in its glow.

"So, yeah, now wha-"Adora began to ask.

"Shut up." Catra stepped up to her and pulled Adora's head down to her own.

No rum, no punch, nothing tainted their passion as their lips met this time. There was just Catra, there was just Adora. They melted into each other, their breathing one, their bodies pressed together. Adora's hands pushing her jacket off Catra's shoulders, Catra's wrapping around Adora's waist. They had moved back into the room and Catra almost fell as the back of her legs met the side of her bed, but Adora's arms would not let her go.

As Adora began to fumble at the zipper of Catra's dress, Catra's hands had found the base of Adora's shirt and began to lift. They laughed into each other's mouths, refusing to separate. They fell onto Catra's bed together.

The End

Chapter End Notes

Yeah the end.
Sorry it's like, short.
I honestly didn't have any ideas beyond like two scenes I had thought of previously, and i have kinda come to hate this whole thing lol.
I have learned a lot writing it though which is good, and I am already writing 2? Definitely at least 1 other thing that I will probably start to post soon. A lot more ideas with that one and I think it's already more words than this whole fic is lol.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!